

CRANK Lead Onboarding Guide

How to be a CRANK Lead: decisions, blockers, and steering ownership.

THE ROLE IN ONE SENTENCE

The CRANK Lead's authority is narrow but unilateral: they own direction and blockers, keep the flywheel moving, and ensure alignment across both KICK meetings. They do not own the product -- that is the Stakeholder. They do not own the build -- that is the Developer. They do not rotate; continuity of context is essential to the role. They are also accountable for the team's Pace Dial setting.

THE THREE KINDS OF CALLS A CRANK LEAD MAKES

- Yes/No calls (most common) -- a Developer or Stakeholder asks whether something can happen mid-cycle. Decided in the room, not after a meeting.
- Direction calls (Navigate) -- pivot or double down, made once per cycle from the Assess lesson, stated as a single clear sentence every Developer can repeat back.
- Delegation calls -- deciding when a blocker or breakout session gets handed off rather than owned personally. Breakout sessions are smaller, informal sessions held mid-cycle to move a specific initiative or development item forward -- delegating them is what frees up the CRANK Lead's time.

OWNING THE PACE DIAL

The team runs at one of three settings -- Full Crank (~2-3 day cycles), Steady (~1 week), or Governed (~2 weeks, releases batched to approval windows, weekly KICKs). They are rough guidelines, not rigid tiers. You are accountable for the setting; the executive sponsor is consulted and must support any change before it takes effect.

- Propose the change in one sentence, naming the real constraint that appeared or lifted.
- Get executive sponsor support before it takes effect.
- Run a cycle reset: close the current cycle -- ship what is ready, document the rest -- and start the next cycle at the new setting.
- Log it in the steering document header: current setting, date, from and to, sponsor, reason, and a review date for any step down.

Default direction is up. Review the setting at every Health Check. A step down is never a way to reset expectations after a miss -- name the miss in Assess first. And a Full Crank team whose cycles drift to a week has not moved to Steady; it has an unplanned slowdown for you to escalate.

THE STEERING DOCUMENT IS YOUR ARTIFACT

The steering document is the single source of truth for direction. It is not a meeting summary -- it is a living, appended record of committed decisions. One entry per decision: a Decision ID, the date and which KICK it came from, the decision itself in one sentence, the rationale, a link back to the originating signal if there is one, the Developer responsible for feasibility review if applicable, and a status of Committed or Superseded. The document header carries the current pace setting, the last setting change, and the setting review date.

Maintenance is yours. In the RACI, the CRANK Lead is Responsible for steering document maintenance -- Developers, Stakeholders, and the Intake Coordinator are Informed or Consulted, not co-owners. If it goes stale, it stops being the source of truth, and the team starts making decisions from memory instead.

BLOCKER RESOLUTION: YOUR PRIMARY JOB

The CRANK Lead owns all blockers unless explicitly delegated. Blocker resolution rate is one of the four core metrics -- target is 90% or higher, resolved before the next KICK. Unresolved blockers that survive more than one KICK indicate the CRANK Lead is overloaded or the delegation is unclear.

- Every open blocker gets named aloud in Blocker Triage (Dev KICK) -- not left implicit.
- The CRANK Lead resolves it, delegates it, or escalates it on the spot. No blocker leaves KICK without a named owner and a next step.
- If a person in a Stakeholder KICK doesn't hold decision authority, that is an Escalation Path item, flagged immediately -- not discovered after the meeting ends.

RUNNING THE TWO KICK MEETINGS

Dev KICK runs on a fixed, scheduled cadence tied to the cycle itself -- every cycle at Full Crank and Steady, weekly at Governed. Stakeholder KICK runs on a cadence agreed with Stakeholders, and weekly at Governed, where it also carries formal sign-off. Both close when alignment is reached, not by the clock.

Dev KICK (facilitate)	Stakeholder KICK (facilitate)
Steer -- confirm priorities still hold	Steer -- confirm or redirect priorities, log new asks
Velocity -- review cycle metrics	Velocity -- share cycle health, numbers not narrative
Blocker Triage -- name and own every blocker	Escalation Path -- flag missing decision authority
Q&A -- no question held back	Q&A + Team Review -- surface misalignment here
Exit / Alignment Check -- every Developer repeats direction back	

YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

Before week 1 -- choose the starting setting: Run the Fit Assessment with the team. Its score recommends Full Crank, Steady, or Governed. Confirm the setting with the executive sponsor and record it in the steering document with a review date.

Week 1 -- pilot cycle: Run one full Charge-Run-Assess-Navigate-Kick rotation on the lowest-stakes work available. Goal is muscle memory, not output quality. Everyone plays every role.

Weeks 2-4 -- cycles 2 through roughly 5: Layer in the Speed Contract explicitly. Call out violations in real time. Focus especially on Developers creating their own tickets instead of receiving them from upstream -- that habit reversal is the most common place teams quietly slide back to old patterns.

By the end of week four, cycle time, blocker resolution, decision latency, and ship rate should all be tracked

against the current setting, you should be able to name your team's single biggest friction point from the data alone, and you should review whether to move the dial up.

COMMON CRANK LEAD MISTAKES

- Seeking consensus instead of deciding -- the single most common failure mode. If every call gets debated to agreement, the role isn't functioning as designed.
- Skipping Assess when the cycle "felt fine" -- real failures don't always look dramatic.
- Letting the steering document go stale -- if it isn't updated every cycle, it stops being the source of truth.
- Making calls outside their lane -- CRANK Lead owns direction and blockers, not the build itself; micromanaging Developer execution erodes ownership.
- Not identifying a backup -- a CRANK Lead with no deputy is a real single point of failure.
- Parking at Governed -- keeping a slower setting after the reason for it is gone.
- Changing pace without a cycle reset or without sponsor support.

SUCCESS INDICATORS

- Cycle time holds within the current setting without you having to force it.
- Blockers get named and owned the moment they surface, not carried silently into the next cycle.
- Developers can repeat the current direction from memory without checking with you first.
- Stakeholder KICK produces real decisions, not a status update they nod through.